
3. What response did you get back?

4. How did you react to that?

5. What did you notice as you stepped back and allowed yourself to see this cycle of reaction and counterreaction?

6. What did you learn about:

Your protector's job or role?

Your protector's wish for you?

How long it has had this job?

What it fears about not responding in this way?

Who it protects?

7. How did your protector respond to your invitation to be in relationship with you in this moment?

Courageous Communication: Change Your Conversation to Change Your Relationship

Couples benefit from learning to speak and listen well. Brain science tells us that empathic communication rewires the brain (Siegel, 2007) and supports changes in patterned behavior. Empathic communication means “feeling with” someone else without getting overwhelmed by their feelings. When we empathize, we feel with—but we don’t confuse ourselves with—the other person: “I can imagine what’s happening for you and resonate with your feelings. Though I know I’m not you, I have these feelings sometimes too.” When we feel compassion for someone else, we care and feel concerned. We want couples to be able to empathize with and feel compassion for each other. In IFIO, we help partners maintain a self-other distinction inside and out so they can empathize safely and feel compassion for each other. Feeling known and understood initiates a positive cycle of connection and caring because it feels so good.

That said, staying curious and open-minded while listening to someone who feels hurt and angry describe the impact of your behavior takes willingness and courage. Speaking and listening well, which both require physiological regulation, call for a level of skill and patience that many couples have not had the opportunity to cultivate. On the other side of the fence, speaking about the other’s impact truthfully without attacking, collapsing, or panicking also takes courage. Good communication requires both partners to stay in the conversation until everyone feels heard and understood, but when protectors feel threatened by differences, they can behave in ways that are far from ideal.

For example, a protector may refuse to listen because it:

- Fears being infected by the other person’s perspective
- Believes listening signals agreement
- Believes they will not be treated fairly and will not have a chance to rebut

Fearful protectors often:

- Move quickly to find a solution to the perceived problem
- Shut down the conversation by “agreeing to disagree”
- Stop listening and focus on formulating a counter-response because they believe listening signals agreement

In IFIO, we help partners tune in to their parts and help them unblend so they have the bandwidth to tune in to their partner and deepen their intimacy, both verbally and nonverbally. Listening is powerful, calming behavior. It invites the same treatment in return. Ironically, the parts who long to

be heard also tend to be protected by parts who associate listening with being powerless and, therefore, refuse to listen. They are afraid of being influenced, controlled, humiliated, or never having the opportunity to be heard. Repetitive patterns of conflict, therefore, involve each partner having an ongoing inner experience of not listening carefully, which is linked to a history of not speaking skillfully.

Even as fighting couples accuse and injure each other, they are wondering, “Do you hear me? Am I safe with you? Will you meet my needs?” But they can’t hear this in themselves because their protectors are busy looking outward, chanting, “*You* can’t be trusted! *You* aren’t safe! *You* won’t meet my needs!” To get to those essential underlying questions, we first help protectors settle down. We start by asking them about their hopes and fears. We listen to them carefully. Wary protectors fear change, and angry protectors like the energy and power of righteous anger. We check for these parts proactively and listen to them carefully too. Once they feel heard, we can offer to help the parts they protect.

Although protective extremes undermine secure attachments and safety, keep in mind that this is not how protectors see it. They operate in a realm—the psyche—where time travel is the norm, and they may be spending more time in a dangerous past than in the present. For them, negative feelings in the present, like fear or shame, simply reinforce storylines from the past (e.g., “I’m being attacked!”). By reacting accordingly, they recreate the kinds of interactions they intended to prevent. In this way, protectors keep the past very much alive and active inside the partners who sit before us. While we honor their urgency and good intentions, we also help them stand down. In particular, we arrange for safe, respectful, and courageous communications by using the U-turn. As protectors stand down, couples gain confidence that they can differ safely and have difficult conversations productively, which, in turn, helps them find a more openhearted perspective on living and being in a relationship.

THE AIMS OF COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION

- Promote unblending and co-regulation.
- Help the couple move safely from content to process.
- Help the protective system trust that a different way of communicating will bring relief.
- Invite vulnerable parts to be seen and heard.

After unblending, each partner practices returning from inner exploration to listen from their Self and speak for their parts. If partners are highly reactive and not well-differentiated internally, this process can be slow. But over time, the whole practice—self-examination, openhearted listening, and unblended speech—generates curiosity about the other person’s experience, as well as a growing acceptance that there is no danger in having different perspectives. When protectors no longer believe that a partner’s differences threaten their survival, dialogue becomes natural and comfortable.

IFIO’s courageous communication borrows from the Imago Dialogue technique (Hendrix, 1988), which was designed to promote a feeling of safety and reveal childhood wounds under troubled interpersonal dynamics. The IFIO version of courageous communication, however, adds an inner dimension to the Imago process by cultivating relationships between each person’s parts and their Self. With healthy inner differentiation and attachment, partners feel safer differentiating from each other and are better able to practice behaviors that create secure interpersonal attachment.

Courageous communication requires attuned listening and responsible self-disclosure. Listening *and* speaking skillfully are both necessary. No one can be present and attentive if their internal system is fighting, fleeing, or numbing. We help the person in the role of listener first by asking them to: (1) listen to their partner’s experience without reacting, (2) wait before responding, and (3) consider the truth in what their partner is saying rather than disagreeing or engaging in self-attack. To help protectors and the ANS relax, we offer the listening partner ample time to express fears. We also invite them to interrupt and ask for help whenever they need.

COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION: PART 1

Listening Skillfully

- Really listening (listening from the Self) when another person describes your impact can be a challenge and takes courage. We invite listeners to be aware that their partner’s feedback is not an objective truth and that listening to their partner is an opportunity to learn something about their partner, themselves, and their relationship.
- Breathing deeply while listening helps. If the listener feels reactive, upset, angry, or vulnerable, they may choose to slow the process down and get help.
- It helps to remind clients that a more vulnerable part who has a need lies beneath their partner’s reactive behavior. Are the listener’s parts willing to relax so they can listen from the Self? Are they available?

- What is the listener hearing? Can they imagine that this feedback will be useful? Are they willing to ask themselves, *What about this rings true and what does not?*
- As they listen, are their parts willing to let them be curious first and speak for their parts with Self-energy after?

Next, we support the speaker by inviting their protectors to speak about their fears. Since protectors often try to get needs met by avoiding conflict, collapsing, manipulating, or bullying, the idea of speaking directly about needs can be a challenge. If they accept this invitation, they let go of power, which some protectors will resist. Threatened, blended protectors raise the speaker's autonomic arousal and set off their impulse to flee, shut down, or fight back (Cozolino, 2008). The speaker can't think or speak when they are in this state. Therefore, we have to help their protectors unblend before proceeding with courageous communication.

COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION: PART 2

Speaking Skillfully

- In order to speak *for* activated parts *from* our Self, we have to be present and take time to understand our parts.
- This is an opportunity for the speaker to talk about their part's experience with another person. Essentially, they speak about what happens inside when they are relating with the other person. The speaker is not evaluating or criticizing their partner. Nor are they trying to help their partner improve, be more self-aware, or be a better person.
- The speaker should consider their goals before speaking. The way they speak (speaking for their parts) will help them speak skillfully and affect the outcome.
- The speaker should ask if their partner is available to listen before beginning.
- Remind the speaker that they will be speaking about their own experience, not an objective reality.
- Before the speaker speaks, they should check inside to determine if their system is ready to explore vulnerable feelings and needs. If the system is ready, they can speak for a need or a fear. If not, the therapist can help the speaker explore whatever concerns came up.

Appreciation and acknowledgment go far in helping angry protectors soften. In particular, threatened protectors are more willing to unblend when we listen carefully, validate their fears, and appreciate their role. It also helps to suggest an alternative to their current strategies for keeping things safe by offering ongoing help. Essentially, we are asking them to sacrifice their current positions for the long-term greater good of themselves and the system they protect, and they need to feel confident of the outcome.

HELPING AN ANGRY PROTECTOR UNBLEND

1. Validate the anger. Make eye contact, be compassionate, and be present. Speak to the protector directly:

“Given that this is your experience...”
2. Validate and empathize with the underlying need. See the exiles beneath the rage. “Your need to be heard makes complete sense...”
3. Challenge the behavior and name the consequence.

“This kind of communication will not get you what you hope for. Your partner will likely not hear you or be able to respond in the way you want them to.”
4. Offer an alternative that includes your help.

“Will you let me help you speak for your feelings and needs?”

ROADMAP FOR INTRODUCING COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION

- Step 1:** Listen, track cycles, and invite the couple to talk about difficult issues in a different way (e.g., “Will you let me help you?”).
- Step 2:** Contract to be their parts detector (e.g., “I am here to help you, so I will slow down or stop the interaction if parts begin to overwhelm”).
- Step 3:** Invite the couple to negotiate who will speak and who will listen first.
- Step 4:** Help the listener prepare by noticing parts who might not want to listen. Encourage the listener to breathe and notice their heart. Help the listener unblend and be emotionally available.

Step 5: Coach the speaker to help their parts unblend and be spoken for. Encourage each partner to stay in relationship with their own parts (e.g., “What are you noticing in your body?”). Do not get caught in content or in helping them find solutions. You may need to ask one partner to wait while you help the other unblend and speak for their parts (e.g., “What is this part concerned would happen if it were to unblend and let you speak for it?”). Validate the experience and feelings of the parts of both partners. Confront protectors firmly and kindly.

Step 6: If appropriate, encourage the speaker to move toward speaking for vulnerable feelings or childhood wounding (e.g., “Are these feelings familiar? Is there something happening that reminds you of your childhood?”).

Step 7: Help the listener respond from the heart with empathy. No part should be left hanging. Some questions and requests to use with the listener include:

- “Can you reflect the essence of what you just heard?”
- “Does any of this information make sense to you? In what way?”
- “What does your heart say?”

If the listener does not empathize with the speaker, offer empathy yourself. Examples of empathic statements include: “The essence of what I’m hearing is...” and “It makes perfect sense to me that...” It is important to meet the client’s self-disclosure with understanding, mirroring, and acknowledgment. Otherwise, a response of deep shame is likely to follow—and perhaps a protective adaptive reaction (Siegel, 2003).

Step 8: Once the speaker has received an empathic response from the listener (or you), ask the listener to pay attention inside.

Step 9: Check back with the speaker. Have they received the response? Has it made an impact? Do the parts who have been spoken for feel understood? Is there anything more to say? The speaker may feel complete and have nothing further to add, or they may feel moved to respond.

Step 10: If there is time, have the listener and speaker switch roles. When switching, remind the couple about the respective jobs of the listener and speaker as needed. When both partners are ready, ask the one who was just listening to speak for their parts.

SETTING THE TABLE FOR A HARD CONVERSATION WITH COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION

Mark and Mateo were cisgendered, European-American, gay men who had no children. At the outset of their relationship 15 years earlier, they had made an agreement that they could each have sexual activity outside their relationship if they practiced safe sex and did not withhold emotional or physical intimacy from each other. They had maintained this arrangement through 12 years of partnership and three years of marriage. Mateo had recently gone through a bout of cancer from which he had recovered completely. Mark had been supportive and available throughout treatment and recovery. Now they sought therapy specifically to improve communication and feel successful when having challenging conversations about sex. Their cycle tended to begin with reactive protectors flaring up and fighting to be heard. Mateo's subsequent response was to withdraw while Mark had a protector who pursued. When a conversation felt threatening, neither of them could regulate their nervous systems long enough to pause, recalibrate, and finish.

In the following dialogue, the therapist sets the table for a courageous conversation by using four U-turn questions. In general, U-turn questions orient partners to notice the feelings, needs, and desires of their parts, which helps their parts unblend. We ask these four U-turn questions at the outset of any conversation the couple has identified as potentially difficult.

Therapist: You've asked for help speaking and listening about your sexual relationship. I hear things are changing, and talking about it has been challenging.

Mateo: Agreed.

Mark: Yes.

Therapist: Before diving in, let's try a short experiment to sort out and understand your parts who have concerns about the conversation to come. Let's start by having both of you listen inside before you speak. As you listen inside and think about starting to talk about your sexual relationship, what parts do you notice?

The first U-turn question

Mark: I feel anxious.

Therapist: How do you notice that in your body?

*Checking for ANS activation and their level
of blending*

Mark: My stomach is tight.

Therapist: Mateo?

Mateo: My stomach too. But I would say I feel more fear more than anxiety.

Therapist: Are you both available to speak for these feelings—these parts—with each other now?

Mateo: *[turning to Mark]* I am really scared about what it will mean if I'm honest. I'm changing. The cancer changed me. So many things are different, and I don't know what's going to happen. Even as I say this, I feel the fear getting bigger.

Therapist: Mateo, let's slow down and notice the fear. Where is it in your body?

Mateo: All over really. I have the urge to disappear.

Therapist: Can you say more?

Mateo: I guess it's a fear of being left... rejected.

Therapist: Does that make sense?

Mateo: It does.

Therapist: Great. Let the part know you get it. What does it need to feel your presence and not take over?

Mateo: *[after a few breaths]* It's actually okay. We've needed to have this conversation for a while. I feel scared, but I trust Mark, and I believe we'll get through it.

Mark: This is helpful. Slowing down rather than jumping in and failing. That's how we get into a gridlock.

Therapist: *[to Mark]* And your anxiety?

Mark: I'm afraid we'll want different things.

Therapist: And then what?

Mark: The relationship will suffer.

Therapist: And then?

Mark: Ultimately, we wouldn't stay together.

Therapist: And...

Mark: I don't want that.

Therapist: So what I'm hearing is that you both have parts who feel anxious about disconnection. Mateo, your parts fear rejection; and, Mark, yours fear the relationship ending. Am I getting this?

Mateo: You are.

Therapist: Does it make sense that talking about sex would be a challenge given all these concerns?

Mark: It makes more sense now.

Therapist: Okay. I have a second question for you both. You have not listened or spoken about this with each other fully. What has that cost you? Again, take a moment to listen inside. When you're ready, speak for the parts you notice.

The second U-turn question

Mark: What I hear inside is that I'm in the dark. I don't know what's up. I've avoided asking Mateo what's going on. I'm worried that I'm going to have to give something up and I'll feel angry, so I just don't say anything.

Therapist: What would be the worst thing about feeling angry?

Mark: Things never go well when I get angry.

Therapist: And the cost of not expressing what you feel?

Mark: Things build up and I get irritable.

Therapist: Thanks. [*turning to Mateo*] What feelings did you notice?

Mateo: Not an angry part but other feelings I'd rather not face.

Therapist: And the cost of not facing them?

Mateo: I just get on with whatever is in front of me, but the feelings do build up.

Therapist: How does not talking about your feelings impact your partner? How does it impact your relationship?

The third U-turn question

Mark: Distance.

Mateo: Distance, avoidance, and superficial conversations.

Mark: Right.

Therapist: Disconnected?

Mark: Yes, disconnected.

Therapist: What are your intentions in having this conversation?

The fourth U-turn question

Mateo: Well, I want to be heard and understood. And, ultimately, I want Mark to be okay and the relationship to be okay.

Mark: I want to understand Mateo, and I want the relationship to stay intact.

Therapist: The fear makes sense to me.

Mark: What I just heard myself say is *I don't know what's going on*. It would probably be useful to find out. So one of my goals is to listen without getting upset.

Mateo: I need to speak up. That's clear. I don't have much of a template for being visible. I was raised by my mother and grandmother—two very strong women, but they kept their mouths shut when they felt threatened. That was the rule.

Therapist: Okay. First, I'd like both of you to take another moment to check inside. Notice your breathing and any shifts in your physical experience, any impulses to fight or pull away.

Checking for ANS activation and their levels of blending

Mateo: I feel more relaxed. Less afraid. I guess those threatened parts are giving me some space.

Verbalizing the experience of unblending

Mark: I'm still anxious because I don't know what I'm going to hear. But less so.

Therapist: And what do you notice in your body? In your stomach?

Mark: More relaxed.

Therapist: Mateo, how's the urge to disappear?

Mateo: I feel more present than I have in a long time.

Therapist: Great. How do you think speaking and listening to each other would go from this place?

Mark: Much better. But I have no idea how to get to this place when we're on our own.

Therapist: Of course, you don't. And that's why we start slowly and practice unblending as we go. We help your parts relax so you can speak for what's going on with them and *respond* instead of *reacting* to each other. Shall we give it a try? [*both agree*]

Once clients have gone through these U-turn questions, their vigilant, concerned parts may be more willing to unblend, at which point the couple can have that courageous conversation, as Mark and Mateo do here.

Therapist: Mark, you said you felt available to listen to what's happening for Mateo. Is that still true?

Mark: It is.

Therapist: [*to Mateo*] And with my help, Mateo, are you ready to start the conversation?

Mateo: With your help? That sounds good. I can feel myself relaxing.

Therapist: [*to Mark*] Scan inside again and notice any parts who have any concerns about listening.

Mark: As I said, I have a part who is afraid Mateo is going to ask me to do something I don't want to do—make changes I'm not ready to make.

Therapist: So this part is worried you will have to do something you don't want to do?

Mark: Yes.

Therapist: What if, for today and perhaps the next couple of sessions, we take making requests and negotiating for needs off the table so we just can concentrate on really listening to each other?

Mateo: That's hard for us. We *really* like to get to the heart of the matter fast so we can figure out what to do.

Therapist: And what is the hope of your get-there-fast parts?

Another U-turn question

Mateo: [*after a moment of silence*] The hope is we get a strategy that will work quickly so we—

Mark: [*interrupting*] So at least we both get something and don't fight.

Mateo: But eventually that leads back to what we were just talking about. We get nowhere or we fight anyway.

Therapist: Exactly! So what do you think about trying something different now? [*they nod*]
Mark, check inside and see if you've got a genuine yes before Mateo speaks.

Mark: [*closes his eyes for a few seconds and then opens them*] Okay, Mateo, let's hear it! I really am interested.

Mateo: [*smiles*] I feel that.

Therapist: Before you speak, Mateo, let me remind you that you're speaking for your parts. For what you want Mark to understand about you right now. If it feels like either of you is getting taken over or flooded, I'll slow everything down to help you unblend. How does that sound?

Contracting to be a "parts detector"

Mateo: Good.

Mark: Great.

Therapist: Are you ready to speak, Mateo?

Mateo: Since my diagnosis and all that followed, something around sex has changed for me. My sex drive isn't the same. I'm rethinking who I am. I was so lucky. Not everyone with a cancer diagnosis survives and goes on like I have.

Mark: [*nods*] I've noticed.

Mateo: [*grimaces*] This is so awkward. Especially in front of a third person.

Therapist: Of course. Can you keep going?

Mateo: I'm really worried that these changes might affect our relationship in big ways—

Mark: *[interrupting]* In what big ways?

Therapist: Mark, what just happened?

Mark: Wow! It must have been that part who is afraid Mateo will ask me for something I can't give.

Therapist: Can you reassure it? Right now, you're just listening.

Mark: Okay, it's settling down. Sorry, Mateo.

Mateo: I'm not asking you for anything. I can barely figure myself out, let alone ask anything of you. I'm afraid, Mark. Afraid!

Therapist: Can you say more about this fear?

Mateo: I'm jumbled inside. I'm not sure.

Therapist: Can we stay with the jumbled feeling for just a moment so you can get a little more information about it?

Mateo: *[closes his eyes and leans back]* In my head, this conversation was going to be about life and death and priorities changing. It still might be. But what I am aware of right now is feeling like damaged goods.

Mark: Oh God. *[grabbing Mateo's hand across the couch]* I'm so sorry you feel that way!

Mateo: *[tearing up]* I wonder if I'm ever going to feel healthy and strong—sexy, desirable—again.

Therapist: Do you know the part who's speaking now, Mateo?

Mateo: I do.

Therapist: And does it feel okay to keep speaking for it to Mark?

Mateo: *[looks at Mark and smiles]* He's sticking around. I guess I can keep speaking for him.

Mark: I'm available. I had no idea. I'm really listening.

Co-regulation



Our job is to support partners in self-regulation and the couple in co-regulation. In this session, the therapist first used four U-turn questions to help Mark and Mateo unblend, listen, and speak differently. As they slowed down, listened inside, and listened to each other about what their parts found most threatening, their vigilant, wary protectors unblended further. But since listening can be scary for protective parts, Mark and Mateo's protectors sometimes popped back in. In anticipation of this, the therapist had asked Mark (the listening partner) if he was getting a "genuine yes," a yes with no caveats from other parts inside. This inquiry helps the listening person scan carefully for objections. Taking the time to connect with the listener's concerned parts helps them relax back. As Mateo and Mark experienced talking without becoming dysregulated, they were able to be as honest and vulnerable as they had hoped.

Therapist Handout

HELPING COUPLES BEGIN HARD CONVERSATIONS

This handout, which details more U-turn questions, illustrates how therapists can help partners unblend, speak for their parts, and listen from the Self. These queries can teach couples how to have any kind of difficult conversation without self-attack or hurting their partner. If a particular conversation causes trepidation in advance, start by talking about having the conversation.

First Inquiry

- Check inside: “When you think about having this hard conversation, what comes up? Which parts activate? What are their concerns?”
- “Instead of speaking *from* your parts (e.g., *I’m anxious about looking into my anger*), speak *for* your parts (*I have a part who feels anxious about finding out why I get so angry*).”

Second Inquiry

- Check inside: “What is the cost of *not* speaking up and *not* having this conversation successfully? Again, speak *for* your parts.”

Third Inquiry

- Check inside: “How do your parts impact your partner? Speak *for* your parts as you consider their impact.”

Fourth Inquiry

- Check inside: “What is your intention in having this conversation? What outcome do you want for you, for your partner, and for your relationship? Speak *for* your parts about their intentions.”

COURAGEOUS COMMUNICATION TOOLBOX: TIPS FOR CLIENTS

- Unblending from your protectors is the key to successful communication. To unblend, experiment with doing a U-turn. How much of this reactivity is your own material? How much is about your partner?
- Make a date to practice speaking and listening well.
- Try speaking vulnerably *for* your parts.
- Experiment with softening your protectors so you can listen.
- Try acknowledging your partner's feelings and experiences before presenting your own.
- Revise blaming language, and practice speaking for your own feelings and needs.
- If you feel overwhelmed, *pause* and come back to the conversation in 20 minutes.
- When you make requests, pay attention to timing. Is this a good moment to bring up this topic?
- Practice making sense of your partner's experience, even if you don't feel like it.
- Reward small attempts at better communication with gratitude and appreciation.

Addressing Emotional Needs with Courageous Communication

Human beings have a biological need to attach, bond, love, and feel secure in their intimate relationships. Babies, as we know, thrive on securely connected interactions (Siegel, 2003). Similarly, intimate relationships thrive when emotional needs are met. However, when clients acknowledge their emotional needs and make requests but are shamed in response, a sense of inadequacy and anger are likely outcomes. In the context of IFIO therapy, these feelings are a window into the client's confusion about what they need and how to make clear requests.

There are a variety of reasons why people struggle to understand their own needs. Many were shamed for having needs early in life. The IFIO approach stipulates that taking care of one's own emotional needs is as essential as caring for a partner. This viewpoint is not intended to make people become islands of self-dependency but to foster self-love. At the same time, when each partner gives *and* receives love freely, understanding their partner's vulnerabilities, the result is deeper mutuality and secure attachment.

To help couples communicate courageously about emotional needs, therapists can follow these six steps:

1. Listen for and name the unmet needs below the client's anger.
2. Help partners identify their pattern of protection (e.g., fight, flee, shut down).
3. Help partners validate and unblend from frustrated protectors who attempt to get needs met in harmful ways.
4. Support each partner in doing a U-turn to explore hidden meanings and core emotional needs.
5. Assist the couple in doing a re-turn so they can request—not demand—that an emotional need be met.
6. Help each partner experiment with *giving* and *receiving* in the moment.

COMMUNICATING WITH COURAGE

The following case vignette illustrates how the U-turn reveals underlying emotional needs. Ulma and Cooper, a cisgendered, European-American, heterosexual couple in their early thirties, came to therapy for help communicating. They loved each other but had volatile and discouraging fights in which their protectors blamed one another and got angry in the hope of changing the other person. After a fight, they would move away from each other to try to regulate themselves, but they rarely returned to the conversation to reconnect positively. Their sessions often began with finger-pointing. In this session, Cooper launched the attack.

Cooper: What the hell, Ulma! How many times do I have to say that texting and texting when you feel insecure is not the way to get my attention? How many times a day?

Ulma: Way to freakin' embarrass me, Cooper! You make me sound like a total idiot.

Cooper: You act like an idiot. What can I say?

Therapist: Okay, let's hold on and back up. Cooper, it sounds like you're frustrated and need something from Ulma. Am I right?

Cooper: Frustrated yes, need something yes! I need her to change this behavior. It's nuts.

Therapist: [to Ulma] This communication from Cooper right now. How is it landing?

Ulma: It's humiliating.

Therapist: That makes sense to me. Can you hold on for a minute while I get curious with Cooper about this part?

Ulma: Please, whatever you have to do. I do not like being portrayed in this way.

Therapist: Cooper, I wonder if we could pause here and notice your frustration. Where is it in or around your body?

Inviting a U-turn by asking the client to notice himself and his body

Cooper: In my chest and arms.

Locating the part in the body

Therapist: Where is it most intense?

Anchoring the part in the body by inviting the client to be very specific

Cooper: My chest.

Therapist: Do you recognize this sensation?

Cooper: I do.

Therapist: Does it have any information for you?

Cooper: It's a fight-or-flight thing.

Naming the ANS response

Therapist: What is your strongest impulse?

Cooper: I want to fight. I want Ulma to hear me!

Therapist: Can you recognize this impulse as a part of you but not all of you?

Checking for unblending

Cooper: Yes.

Therapist: Then let's say hi to this part. And notice how you feel toward it.

Befriending the part

Cooper: [*sighs and focuses inward*] I feel okay. I know this feeling.

Therapist: What do you know about it?

Cooper: It means I'm afraid.

Therapist: A part of you is afraid?

Asserting the importance of parts language

Cooper: Maybe that I can't meet all of her needs?

Therapist: And what else does the part say?

Cooper: I'll never get what I need.

Therapist: Which is?

Cooper: I don't even know...

Therapist: This is important. So let's be sure we understand. You have needs. But what are they? Your needs can't get through to you. And then Ulma comes along and seems to be expecting you to do something about her needs. I'm guessing this all feels like too much for your frustrated part. Who will meet all of these needs, inside and out?

Naming the projection: "When your protectors exile your needs, they will also exile her needs."

Cooper: Yeah. Who will?

At this point, the therapist invited Cooper to speak *for* his frustrated part. We always aim for unblended speech, which fosters a *re-turn* to the partner with a broader perspective, a relaxed nervous system, and the readiness to reconnect. When we speak for a part, we honor its need to be heard clearly, which helps it be willing to unblend.

Therapist: That is a great question, Cooper. Let me help. Okay? First, I'll invite you to experiment with speaking *for* your frustrated part with Ulma.

Cooper: You mean instead of always saying what the part is upset about?

Therapist: That's right. I want you to speak to Ulma about what you just learned inside, starting with what happened in your body and moving to the fears.

Cooper: [turning to Ulma] You heard all that, right?

Ulma: I did. I'm grateful to hear it like that instead of the usual way. And I wouldn't mind hearing it again. Less choppy.

Cooper: Okay. First, I notice that when you ask for attention—especially in the middle of the day—I get physically agitated, and then I start a fight with you. I know this doesn't go well. I have fears. One, that I can't meet your needs, and two, I keep hearing, "What about me? What about my needs? Is she paying attention to what it might be like for me right now?" I don't know how to be successful in this area, so a part of me gets frustrated and pushes back. When I experience myself as incompetent or not taken into consideration, it's not my strong suit. I can't handle that.

In contrast to Cooper's opening statement ("What the hell, Ulma!"), Cooper and Ulma were now able to communicate more vulnerably, addressing their fears and needs.

Ulma: I hear you and that makes sense. It would be great to know what you need. I have no idea.

Cooper: That makes two of us.

Therapist: How was this communication compared to the way you usually speak and listen?

Ulma: So much better! Thank you.

Therapist: Cooper?

Cooper: Better, I guess. But now I just feel... empty and sad.

Therapist: I'm not surprised. I know this is painful. We will help that part too. Our next step will be discovering what you need and inviting Ulma to meet those needs.

Offering possibility



This vignette illustrates the IFIO therapist proffering a non-threatening invitation to one partner to do a U-turn, explore their feelings safely, unblend from activated parts, speak for their fears, and

then re-turn to relational connection. The following **U-Turn and Re-Turn for Couples** worksheet provides a simple seven-step exercise that clients can use to help reactive parts unblend so they can speak to each other with insight rather than fear. This exercise can also be useful between sessions.

In addition, the **A Choice in Every Moment** worksheet helps couples break their patterns of reaction and counterreaction as they try to get their emotional needs met. Couples in conflict are generally blended with protective parts who believe that the only way to get their needs met is to counter the other person. This worksheet illustrates how partners can respond more effectively once they understand the following: (1) a knee-jerk response signals an unmet need; (2) by tracking under their frustration, they will discover the needs of a part who is stuck in a toxic childhood event; and (3) requests imbued with Self-energy are far more persuasive than demands from edgy protectors.

Finally, the **Finding and Speaking from Emotional Needs** worksheet can help clients slow down, make a U-turn, and explore deep longings and needs that were exiled in childhood, which are not being met in their current relationship. After using the worksheet to write about what they learned, invite clients to re-turn and speak from an unblended place for their parts, and then have them experiment with making requests.

In IFIO, we believe that the ability to ask and respond to emotional needs is key to intimacy. Since it's best for clients to practice making requests in session before doing so at home, we suggest helping them complete the exercise in session.

Client Worksheet**THE U-TURN AND RE-TURN FOR COUPLES**

Learning to make a U-turn, unblend from reactive parts, and speak *for* them instead of *from* them is the key to having hard conversations safely. The process supports each person in gaining clarity, calming the nervous system, and getting perspective on the needs beneath their reactivity. This worksheet is a roadmap for the U-turn and can be used in the office with the help of a therapist or in between sessions.

1. Pause, breathe, and do a U-turn by focusing your attention inward.
2. Pay attention to your body. Describe your:

Breathing

Heart rate

Muscle tension

Inner voices

Impulses

3. Befriend the parts you notice by saying hi and letting them know you're here to listen and learn. What do you say to these parts?

4. Explore your part's fears and vulnerabilities.

What do they fear?

What's under that fear?

What do they need?

5. Report what you learned.

In my body, I noticed:

I have a part who fears:

6. Speak for these parts.

I have a part who needs:

I have a part who wants:

7. Make a request from the Self. What is the core need?

Client Worksheet**A CHOICE IN EVERY MOMENT**

In relationships, we often view frustration and anger as protective attempts to get emotional needs met. With the help of your therapist, use this worksheet to understand the emotional needs behind your frustration or anger and to learn to make requests from your Self instead of making demands from protectors. Partners respond better to an invitation than an obligation.

1. Focusing on your feeling of frustration, what do you notice?

2. What words do you hear?

3. What is your normal (“knee-jerk”) response when you are frustrated?

4. Which parts of you react (e.g., controlling, angry, impatient, manipulative, submissive, analyzing)?

5. What response does your reaction elicit from your partner’s parts?

6. What happens *inside* you when you get this response from your partner’s parts (e.g., angry, sad, happy, excited, anxious)?

7. What do you notice about this cycle of reaction and counterreaction between your protective parts and your partner’s protective parts?

8. Can you see, feel, or sense the vulnerable part underneath your protector's frustrated reaction? What do you know about that part?

9. What pattern of interactions or incidents in childhood wounded you?

10. What core need did your young, wounded part look for but not get (e.g., to be heard, noticed, loved, witnessed, held, understood, feel connected)?

Client Worksheet**FINDING AND SPEAKING FOR EMOTIONAL NEEDS**

This exercise is a clarifier. Feelings (and the needs they speak for) find expression in the body before becoming conscious thought. By turning to the body with our full attention, we tap into a wealth of crucial information. As the poet, Rumi, said, “The cure for pain is in the pain. These pains you feel are messengers. Listen to them.” After listening, speak for the parts you hear. When we listen to parts carefully and speak for their needs, we receive their gifts in return.

1. Close your eyes, take a few deep breaths, and turn your focus inward. Think of a person in your life with whom you have an intimate connection who can anger or frustrate you. Call that person up in your mind’s eye and invite them to do or say that angering or frustrating thing. Observe your reactions:

What do you feel in your body?

What do you hear yourself saying to yourself?

What feelings are you aware of?

What is your first impulse?

Can you recognize this impulse as a “part” of you?

2. Now let the image of this person float away, and invite your reactive part to turn toward you and begin a gentle inquiry:

What is your role?

What are you concerned would happen if you didn't react this way?

Who are you protecting?

What vulnerability concerns you?

What childhood incident(s) launched this pattern of reactivity?

3. Now ask yourself: What did this young part of you need and not get from an adult at that time? Listen for core needs, like the need to be heard, noticed, loved, witnessed, held, understood, or to know you are not alone. Relax and listen. Don't push for an answer or rush your parts. Allow them to take their time and give you information.

4. Are you available to meet those needs internally right now? Can you be present to that child in the here and now? Why or why not?

5. To end this inquiry, thank your parts for any and all information, no matter how much or how little. And then check in again with your reactive part. How is it feeling?

6. Finally, ponder this question: What would it be like to speak for those underlying needs instead of speaking from your reactive parts?

Giving and Receiving with Courageous Communication

Giving and receiving love, care, and support in intimate relationships is a complex process for several reasons. Partners in a reciprocal relationship generally establish either an overt or a covert contract that governs how and when their needs will or will not be met. When these agreements are covert, partners struggle that much more to identify what feels loving and to express love in ways their partner will be able to receive.

Because systems need balance, imbalance in a relationship erodes the confidence and security of partners, especially when the imbalance continues over time. For example, let's say the strong caretaking parts of one partner activate the longing for rescue in their partner's exiles. The longing of exiles, in turn, rouses vigilant, reactive protectors whose mission is to protect those exiles. These parts view the caretaking behavior as potentially disappointing and oppressive. They are scared of the caretaker—not grateful. When they lash out, the caretaker is surprised and hurt, and believes their partner is ungrateful. In IFIO therapy, we want the couple to understand this kind of struggle over giving and receiving care.

GIVING AND RECEIVING

Reed and Sloane, a cisgendered, heterosexual, European-American couple in their early fifties, were both divorced and had only been together for a couple of years when they came to therapy with a goal of breaking old patterns that were endangering their relationship. Reed was a man of his community with a reputation for generosity and service to others. Sloane, an artist, had good friends but was more of an introvert. Sloane had recently been diagnosed with chronic fatigue syndrome and had less energy and stamina for a shared social life. They had been in therapy for more than a year when they had this discussion about giving and receiving.

Sloane: I want to say something. It's the time of year when people give parties, and we've been invited to two over the coming weekend. We're going away next week, and just getting ready is a huge stretch for me—I'm not saying it should be, just that it is. So I told Reed I can't go to the parties. But I have a part who thinks I'm a drag and worries about losing him. So [*turning to Reed*] I want you to know that I will go if you tell me that it's important to you. I'll go to either party or both.

Reed: Oh no. Why would you do that?

Sloane: For you. [*Reed looks down and fidgets*]

Therapist: Can I jump in here? [*they nod*] What are you feeling right now, Reed?

Reed: My skin is crawling.

Therapist: What are you hearing?

Reed: “We don’t do that!”

Therapist: Who is that?

Reed: My father.

Therapist: A part who sounds like your father or your father?

Reed: I don’t know.

Therapist: Ask.

Reed: A part.

Therapist: And why is it representing your father right now?

Reed: “Father knows best!” [*everyone laughs*]

Therapist: And what does this father part have to say about giving and receiving?

Reed: “Don’t be selfish!”

Therapist: What would be selfish?

Reed: Needs.

Therapist: So let’s do a thought experiment. How would it feel if you were to say to Sloane right now, “Yes please do come! It means a lot to me to have you by my side at the party. I want you there.”

Reed: [*wrinkling his nose*] I can’t do that!

Sloane: You can’t?

Therapist: Let me slow you down here. You, Reed, have a part who is allergic to receiving. And you, Sloane, have a part who feels something about that response. What do you feel?

Sloane: Diminished.

Therapist: [*to Reed*] Do you understand that?

Reed: We must be onto something because I have a part who is yelling, “No! No! No! No!”

Therapist: Can we check in with that part? [*Reed nods, the therapist looks at Sloane*]

Sloane: Go for it.

Therapist: How do you feel toward the part who just said no?

Reed: Sorry for it.

Therapist: What is it concerned about?

Reed: Weakness.

Therapist: Receiving is weak?

Reed: I guess so.

Therapist: [*to Sloane*] Does Reed do things for you?

Sloane: He's the soul of generosity.

Therapist: How do you make sense of Sloane's annoyance when you're so generous?

Reed: [*chuckling*] Do I have to?

Therapist: Can I guess? I want your parts to tell me what I get wrong.

Reed: Please.

Therapist: You have a part we know pretty well who wants you to be good so you'll be loved. He protects a little boy whose father could terrify him, and he couldn't go complaining to his mother. Right so far? [*Reed nods*] And you have another part, a rebellious teenager, who doesn't want to be good. Sometimes he just takes over and acts rude and selfish. Right? [*Reed and Sloane nod*] And people are shocked by that teenage part.

Sloane: That would be me!

Therapist: The teenager desperately wants to be free and unconstrained by the good boy.

Reed: Yes.

Therapist: So who wants you to do all this giving: the good boy or the rebel?

Reed: The good boy, without a doubt.

Therapist: How do you feel toward him now?

Reed: [*shaking his head*] I'm amazed he's still going so strong.

Therapist: And given how strong he is, how do you feel toward him?

Reed: I wish he'd go away. [*before the therapist can respond, Sloane speaks*]

Sloane: [*nods*] The teenager hurts me and makes me mad sometimes, but the good boy scares me.

Therapist: [*to Reed*] Are you open to hearing about that?

Reed: Yes.

Sloane: If receiving is weak—and you do help me, and I do receive your help—then what am I? [*Reed nods thoughtfully*] How can I accept your help if I can't do anything for you in return? When you refuse my help, I feel small and... insignificant.

Reed: I hear you. But I just can't imagine changing.

Therapist: What's the fear?

Reed: I'll be bad.

Therapist: And then?

Reed: [*after a long pause*] I'll feel small and insignificant.

Therapist: The boy?

Reed: It always comes back to him. Why hasn't he been helped yet?

Therapist: Yeah, why?

Reed: Fear?

Therapist: Of him?

Reed: Of being like him.

Therapist: What is he like?

Reed: Insignificant and weak!

Therapist: Can we get permission to help him?

Reed: [*shakes his head in amazement*] I don't think so. I'm not getting a yes on that.

Sloane: Who won't let you help him?

Reed: Well... there's a part who says, "What about me?"

Therapist: Is that the good boy speaking? [*Reed nods*] How do you feel toward him right now?

Reed: I care about him.

Therapist: If we help the little one, wouldn't that help the good boy too?

Reed: But what would happen to me?

Speaking from the good boy part

Therapist: *[speaking to the good boy part directly]* You won't disappear. There's room for everyone. *[Reed is silent]* Can we do a little experiment? *[they nod]* Okay. Reed ask Sloane to move closer to you. *[Reed looks paralyzed.]*

Therapist: What's happening to you right now?

Reed: It's hard.

Therapist: What are you hearing?

Reed: "We don't ask others to do our dirty work."

Therapist: If you were to ask Sloane to sit closer to you right now, what need would you be asking her to fill?

Reed: To feel less alone. *[looking at Sloane]* To know I was a priority. To know I don't always have to worry about other people. To feel important. *[Sloane slides across the couch and takes one of Reed's hands. He blinks tears away. They are silent.]* I can barely breathe.

Therapist: What would happen if you breathed?

Reed: *[Covers his eyes, leans forward and weeps. When his breath calms, he sits up and looks from Sloane to the therapist and back.]* I would grieve.



Balanced give-and-take in a partnership is essential. As we see in this couple's interaction, the burden of equating giving with strength and receiving with weakness undermines the balance in their intimacy. Of course, the person who refuses to receive discourages others from giving, but that is only part of this burden's cost. Ultimately, one person not receiving either sours the other person on receiving or puts them in the position of a child. Reed's good boy part feared losing his job and his reason for existing, but when Reed spoke for his underlying needs, the good boy's opposition melted for the moment, and Reed was able to feel sad. Just as internal shifts flow outward, relational shifts flow inward.

Projection: The Cost of Hidden Parts

Our protectors respond to attachment injury by hiding those parts of us who seem vulnerable, who seem to create the conditions for more injury. In order to disown the dangerous vulnerability of these exiled parts, clients often engage in projection by criticizing a disowned quality as it shows up (or seems to show up) in others. Managers who project criticize internally and then externally. For example, if a client's family (or culture) frowns on direct expressions of anger, their managers will make a big effort to suppress and hide parts who get angry. Projection is one way of doing this. We see this when one partner's angry protector insists that the other person in the couple is the angry one: *I'm not angry, you're angry*. When we project, we reject not only our own important feelings (and parts), but also the actual feelings (and parts) of the other person.

When a couple's interpersonal conflicts center on projection, we can use the following two U-turn exercises to help them take back their projections and love their disowned parts.

The first of these U-turn exercises illustrates how protectors project vulnerability and place blame for suffering on others. When this exercise is done with respect, it can help partners befriend some of their most difficult or elusive parts. The second U-turn exercise presented here helps partners notice the ways in which they abandon their injured parts when they let their protectors jump to the barricades. While the U-turn is tremendously beneficial in any relational conflict, it can be a challenge.

Clients may feel disoriented as they bring the qualities their protectors have tried to hide with projection (insisting they are features of someone else) to light. Therefore, we start by helping clients honor these protectors and understand their motives.

Client Worksheet**DO A U-TURN WITH YOUR PARTS**

“Doing a U-turn” means turning your attention inside, to your own parts, when you have a feeling or reaction to someone else that you want to learn more about. Most of us have protectors who deflect attention from vulnerability by downplaying the importance and meaning of our feelings (that is, the feelings of other parts internally) by insisting that some external person caused us to feel that way. Instead of taking this inner voice of blame at face value, we can treat it as a signal that some other part of us, either another protector or an exile, needs to be heard. The U-turn liberates us from the paralysis and powerlessness of blame.

1. First, think of someone in your life who offends you. Make this personal. What does this person do or say that is offensive? Listen to your judging part as you describe them.

2. Then ask yourself the following questions:

What do your parts want this person to *do* differently?

Who do your parts want this person to *be* for you?

What advice do your parts have for this person?

Let your critic judge this person without censoring. List your thoughts about the person’s behavior in this situation.

What is it about this situation that your parts don’t ever want you to experience again?

In order to feel less offended and be happier in a relationship with this person, how do your parts want you to act with this person?

3. Now ask the critic to give you some space inside to be curious and to listen, and when you can feel that space, do a U-turn. First, turn global criticisms about this person into factual observations.

-
4. Now ask yourself: When someone treats me badly, how do I treat myself? Do my parts criticize me? Do my parts plot revenge? Do my parts repeatedly avoid accepting and feeling sad about what happened by rehearsing a different scenario with a different outcome? If so, ask them: Whom do you protect?
-

5. Once you have uncovered the part of you who is being protected, with permission, ask that part: What happens to you while these other parts are criticizing, plotting, and undoing?
-

6. Now check again: Do you still have space inside to be curious and to listen? If so, inquire about which of your parts are involved in the relationship with this person, and consider how your parts behave. Make a list of these parts, and set an intention to get to know them better.
-

Adapted from the work of Byron Katie

Client Worksheet**A U-TURN IN A THOUGHT EXPERIMENT**

It's not easy to notice our own projections—protectors who use this strategy don't intend us to notice ourselves at all. This thought experiment asks you to revisit an activating situation by going inside and noticing in hindsight. This is a good way to introduce yourself to protective parts who only come out for emergencies and can otherwise be hard to find. This is an opportunity to meet your protectors and find your exiles.

1. Go back to a situation when someone hurt you. Notice how your protectors reacted. Did they immediately start thinking about what to *do*? If so, what was it? And what did they do? Did your response include: insisting on being understood correctly, complying to forestall conflict, or plotting for revenge? Jot down whatever you learn.

2. Now ask the parts who reacted to join you in answering these questions:

Which part got hurt in that situation?

What happened to the hurt part when other parts reacted?

Will the reactive parts give you permission to help the part who got hurt? Why or why not?

Would the hurt part like help? Why or why not?

3. Then consider these questions:

Have I behaved in the same (hurtful) way with other people? How so?

Do I have parts who act this way internally? If so, which parts?

What other parts of this person have I noticed?

How do those parts behave? Make a list.

Intrapsychic Work in Couple Therapy: Going Inside

At various points in IFIO couple therapy, one partner bears witness as the other explores their inner experience. We typically do this individual work within couple therapy for one of these reasons: (1) one partner has a part who is highly charged and won't unblend, (2) patterns of behavior appear entrenched, or (3) negative childhood experiences or shame about having needs begin to surface. While unconventional, individual work in the context of couple therapy can be deeply healing. When a person attends to their wounded, burdened parts with compassion, they re-turn to their partner feeling safer, calmer, braver, and, thus, more available. The inner security that comes from accessing the Self sets the table for acknowledging how negative beliefs (e.g., "I'm unlovable") have impacted their relationship and their partner.

Meanwhile, the witnessing partner sees that vulnerability while also seeing their loved one's strength, resilience, and presence. In many cases, this shared experience challenges the couple's view of each other as just the "wounder" or the "caretaker," and gives them freedom to explore what they actually need and want in their relationship today. When intimate relationships become challenging, implicit memories based on preverbal experiences will begin to surface. We aim to bring implicit memories into awareness so that, over time, the couple can change their perceptions, feelings, and thoughts about themselves and each other (Badenoch, 2008).

In addition to showing partners how childhood experiences influence adult behavior, there are other benefits to individual work in the context of couple therapy. First, the partner who is engaging in self-exploration promotes secure attachments between the Self and their parts, helping parts heal

from negative beliefs acquired during childhood. Second, the witnessing partner takes an active role in their partner's healing process by listening with empathy and compassion to painful childhood dilemmas. When one person is inside witnessing a wounded, vulnerable part with deep love and caring, and their partner holds that vulnerability with love and caring as well, a positive cycle of healing ensues. The inclusive nature of the IFIO model invites relational healing inside and out.

GOING INSIDE

Step One: Contract with the couple and let them know that one person will be going inside while the other serves as a witness.

Step Two: Support the witnessing person to unblend so they can listen and stay present. Remind them that you are there to help if they